

|1994| TWO BEAUTY TITLES

## First the Universe, Then the World

The world sits up to take notice as two girls win beauty pageants and a grooming industry takes off

Goa lends itself to letting oneself go. But on the night of January 16, 1994, after the Miss India pageant ended, Aishwarya Rai boxed herself inside her hotel room. Everyone else bundled on to the sandy shore but friend and designer Hemant Trevedi stayed back. Rai, the favourite for the crown, had been pipped by a struggling Delhi model called Sushmita Sen. "I talked to her for a long time and told her that she would one day make history," says Trevedi. And she did. On November 19, Rai bowed her head to the blue Miss World crown. Her win only added to India's strides on the international beauty map. Just a few months earlier, Sen had patented the hands-on-mouth-in-awe pose that has now become a pageant favourite. For the first time an Indian had won the Miss

Universe crown. For an aspirational India, heady from the early days of liberalisation, they were the poster girls. "In the 1980s, poor was good, rich was bad. The '90s allowed people to feel good without feeling bad," says Anand Halve, co-founder of the brand consultancy firm Chlorophyl. The build-up had started a few years ago. "Madhu Sapre was the second runner-up at Miss Universe 1992 and Indian girls were getting confident," Trevedi says. In 1994, nothing was left to chance. Fitness expert Rama Bans put Sen under a Firm and Full machine, designed to enhance the bust. Trevedi designed 40 costumes for Rai. It soon seemed that Indian women could do no wrong. A year later, Manpreet Brar was crowned first runner-up at Miss Universe. In 1997, Diana Hayden was crowned Miss World, a feat repeated by Yukta Mookhey in 1999. India's run peaked in 2000, when Lara Dutta, Priyanka Chopra and Dia Mirza, won all the major titles. Along with the attention, came the cynicism. Many argued that India's dream run was because international beauty brands were entering the country. Over the years, these

pageants have lost their shine. Today television and films have taken that place. Avenues might have increased today, but 1994 will always remain the year when two Indian girls made the world sit up and take notice. *by Jhilmil Motihar*

### ALSO

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- Kiran Bedi bags the Magsaysay Award for Government Service
- Vishwa Mohan Bhatt wins a Grammy award



### THE MAIN EVENT

## India Ratifies WTO Agreement

Had it been done by a huge propaganda machine, it couldn't have achieved more success. As representatives from 124 countries gathered in Marrakesh, Morocco, to sign the largest-ever pact in history, members of the Opposition, notably the Left parties and the BJP, spread out in the villages to sow the seeds of discontent and confusion. And in the process stoked old and new fears: multinationals would come in freely and reduce the people to penury; Indian agriculture is being taken over by foreigners; a general international conspiracy is on to enslave India. Despite the rhetoric from those opposing the Uruguay Round of the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade to be converted into the WTO, people are no wiser about the threats posed by the agreement.

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RAI AT THE MISS WORLD PAGEANT;  
SEN IS CROWNED MISS UNIVERSE (TOP)

